

Minto Pyramid Principle & SCQA

Minto Pyramid Principle

Think Top-Down. Communicate Bottom-Up.

1 TOP LEVEL

State your main conclusion or recommendation.



MAIN CONCLUSION / ANSWER

The one key message or recommendation.

Start with the Answer

Lead with your conclusion or recommendation so your audience knows where you're going.

2 MECE GROUPING

Support your answer with 3-7 key supporting points that are mutually exclusive and collectively exhaustive.



KEY POINT 1
Supporting argument

KEY POINT 2
Supporting argument

KEY POINT 3
Supporting argument

KEY POINT 4
Supporting argument

Group Your Ideas

Break down the main conclusion into logical, MECE* supporting points.

*MECE = Mutually Exclusive, Collectively Exhaustive

3 SUPPORTING DETAILS

Provide evidence, data, examples and analysis to support each point.



Detail / Evidence / Fact

Detail / Evidence / Fact

Detail / Evidence / Fact

Detail / Evidence / Fact

Detail / Evidence / Fact

Detail / Evidence / Fact

Detail / Evidence / Fact

Detail / Evidence / Fact

Detail / Evidence / Fact

Detail / Evidence / Fact

Detail / Evidence / Fact

Detail / Evidence / Fact

Support with Evidence

Use facts, data, examples and analysis to justify each supporting point.

HOW IT WORKS



- Start at the top with your answer.
- Organize your supporting points into logical groups.
- Provide detailed evidence to support each point.
- This creates clarity, logical flow, and strong persuasion.

THE RESULT



Your audience quickly understands your main message and the key reasons and evidence behind it.

"Hierarchy in thinking becomes hierarchy in communication."

– Barbara Minto

SCQA FRAMEWORK

A Simple Structure for Powerful Communication.



SITUATION

Set the context.

Provide the background and set the stage.



COMPLICATION

Present the problem.

Highlight the challenge, gap or underlying issue.



QUESTION

Focus attention.

Ask a thought-provoking question that drives thinking.



ANSWER

Provide the resolution.

Deliver your answer, recommendation or next steps.

S – SITUATION



- Describe the current situation
- Share relevant facts and data
- Help your audience understand the context
- Keep it concise and relevant

EXAMPLE

Our customer onboarding process currently takes an average of 8 days and involves multiple manual steps across different teams.

C – COMPLICATION



- Identify the problem or challenge
- Explain why it matters
- Highlight the impact or risk
- Create a sense of urgency or need

EXAMPLE

This leads to a 30% error rate in document verification, customer frustration, higher operational costs, and delayed time-to-value.

Q – QUESTION



- Ask a question that engages your audience
- Make them think about the implications
- Bridge the problem to the solution

EXAMPLE

How might we reduce onboarding time and errors while improving compliance and customer experience?

A – ANSWER



- Provide the answer or recommendation
- Present the benefits
- Suggest clear next steps
- End with confidence

EXAMPLE

We recommend implementing an AI-powered document verification solution that reduces onboarding time to 2 days, improves accuracy to 95%, and enhances compliance.

HOW SCQA WORKS



Captures Attention
The Situation sets the scene and connects.



Builds Relevance
The Complication highlights the real issue.



Drives Engagement
The Question sparks curiosity and dialogue.



Delivers Impact
The Answer provides clarity, value and action.

BEST PRACTICES

- ✓ Keep it simple and structured
- ✓ Focus on your audience
- ✓ Be concise and relevant
- ✓ Tailor the depth to the audience
- ✓ End with clear next steps



"SCQA helps you think clearly, communicate logically, and persuade effectively." – Barbara Minto

